

### Beyond the good news

Questions have been raised about the long-term viability of big-ticket events like the National Games. Uttarakhand has previously faced the prospect of sporting infrastructure going to waste — their indoor ice skating rink, constructed for the South Asian Games at a cost of over 100 crore rupees in 2011, is currently defunct, with plans being made to turn it into a regular indoor venue. With equipment and facilities constructed at a cost of hundreds of crores this time, the challenge will be to keep them in use.

One of the purposes of the Games is to promote a sporting legacy. Although Uttarakhand achieved its best-ever performance at the National Games, finishing seventh in the medal tally with 24 golds and 103 overall, complaints were raised that not all the medal winners were from the state.

With the state government promising jobs and large sums of money to medal winners, there was ample incentive to field players who weren't homegrown — defeating the purpose of the Games to begin with.

The state's first gold medal was won by Tapas Achom in the wushu competition. Achom, however, is a native of Manipur. Narender Berwal, who won gold in the 91+ kg category of men's boxing, is a resident of Haryana. Multiple allegations were also made against their canoeing team.

An official complaint was raised by the Telangana team in the beach handball competition, alleging that Uttarakhand had fielded six players who were not eligible to participate according to the competition rules. Another complaint was made with the same objection in the men's indoor event. Both complaints were rejected, with the Uttarakhand team winning silver and bronze in the two competitions.

These, however, are not issues restricted to Uttarakhand alone. Previous hosts Goa were hit with the



## SIXTEEN-YEAR-OLD SURYAKSH RAWAT WAS PRAISED BY DOUBLE OLYMPIC MEDALLIST PV SINDHU AFTER REACHING THE FINAL OF THE BADMINTON MEN'S SINGLES CATEGORY

same charges when they conducted the Games in 2023 as well. Indeed, Uttarakhand also had genuine home-grown stars of their own, with Ankita Dhyani winning gold in the 3000m steeplechase and 5000m while also taking silver in the 10000m.

The final impact of the Games will be seen in the years to come. It remains to be seen whether

Uttarakhand will make full use of its facilities and whether its athletes can continue to perform at the same level.

It also remains to be seen whether the next host, Meghalaya, will avoid these unsavoury practices. Should they do so while maintaining what went right in Uttarakhand, the 2027 Games will be a net positive for Indian sport.